

INTERPRETING DIVINE WILL

divination in ancient Greece

The ancient Greeks constantly sought to understand the will of the gods by reading signs in natural events, animals, or objects, or by attempting to communicate directly with them. In a world where it seemed all too easy to anger the gods and for terrible punishments to befall mortals who did, Greeks were anxious to divine the intentions of the gods and learn how to win their favor.

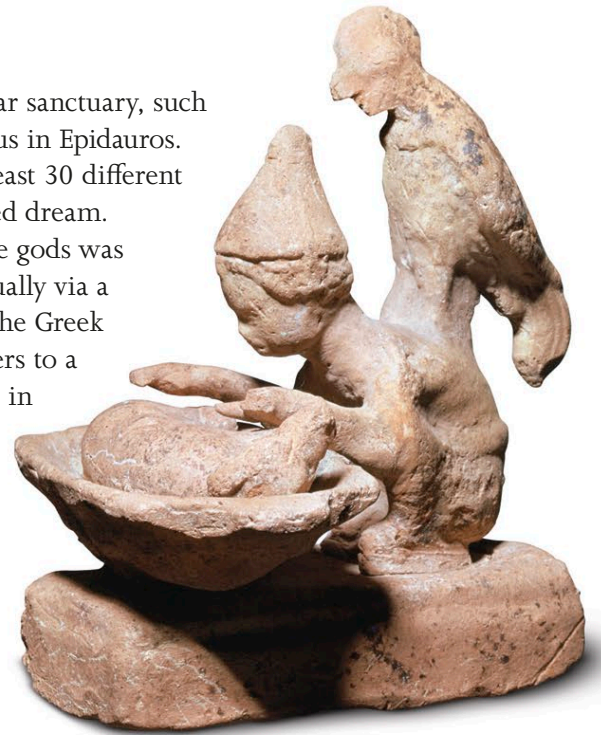
Diviners and oracles

The practice of divination was first recorded in the *Iliad*, a poem about the Trojan War. In it, the hero Achilles suggests consulting a “reader of dreams” to learn why the god Apollo was angry with the Greeks.

There were various ways to seek out divine will. Specialist diviners observed the flight of birds (ornithomancy)—a bird flying high, and with outstretched wings, was a good omen; or the livers of sacrificial animals (hepatomancy)—any abnormalities were a bad sign. The gods could also answer a question by the way diviners drew lots or cast knucklebones, or by indicating letters on an alphabet board with a swinging ring suspended on a thread. Closer contact with the gods could be obtained by interpreting the dreams

of someone sleeping in a particular sanctuary, such as that of the healing god Asclepius in Epidauros. The Greek Magical Papyri list at least 30 different rituals to obtain a divinely inspired dream.

The most direct approach to the gods was through oracles (godly advice, usually via a priestess). At shrines throughout the Greek world, priestesses delivered answers to a petitioner’s questions, often while in a divine frenzy (the mania that gave Greek divination its name, *mantike*). The most famous shrine was at Delphi, where the Pythia, priestess of Apollo, gave advice while in an ecstasy inspired by fumes from an underground cave. Many cities petitioned the Delphic priestess on matters of state importance, though her oracular replies were cryptic. When in 546 BCE Croesus, king of Lydia, asked if he should engage in battle with the invading Persians, the response was that if he did so he would destroy a great empire. Croesus then assumed he should attack, but was so badly defeated that his own “empire” was destroyed.



▲ Extispicy

In this 6th-century BCE terra-cotta, a priest prepares to remove the entrails of a sacrificial pig to divine the future: this practice was known as extispicy.

IN CONTEXT

Pythagoras and numerology

The 6th-century BCE Greek mathematician Pythagoras and his followers believed that the universe was intimately connected with numbers, and that by understanding them past events could be understood and future ones divined. Some numbers had special properties: 2 and 3 were considered male and female, and their sum, 5, was associated with marriage; the addition of 1, 2, 3, and 4 made the perfect number, 10 (the same as the number of heavenly bodies), and was particularly auspicious. A later technique, attributed to Pythagoras, assigned a number to each letter of the alphabet; adding up those of a specific name gave a magical insight into that name.

Pythagoras (right) works at a counting board in a calculation competition with Boethius, who uses written Hindu-Arabic numbers, watched over by the figure of Arithmetic.

